ST. CHARLES PREPARATORY SCHOOL

PreACT Math — Test Day

Algebra 1 · Mr. Nappier · taken online

WHAT YOU ARE WALKING INTO

Pace	About 1 minute per question. That is the whole game — it is a speed test more than a hard test.
Order	Roughly easiest to hardest. If question 6 is fighting you, you have misread it.
Choices	Four answers on the new form. If you see five, that is fine — the older form is still in use.
Formulas	You are given NONE. Area, slope, Pythagorean, and the quadratic formula have to be in your head.
Wrong answers	Cost nothing. There is no penalty for guessing, so no box may be left empty.

BECAUSE IT IS ON A SCREEN

- You cannot write on the question. Your scratch paper is the only place to think — fold it in four and work one quadrant per question so your own numbers never run together.
- Copy the figure, not the whole problem. Redrawing a triangle with its labels is nearly always faster than re-reading the screen three times.
- Use the flag tool, and trust it. Flag and move on; do not drift back. One pass forward, then the flags.
- Watch the clock at the thirds, not constantly. Check it once around question 12 and once around question 24. If you are behind, start guessing the long ones immediately — that is a decision, not a surrender.

THREE PASSES, IN THIS ORDER

- PASS 1 — anything you can finish in under a minute. Take every one of these. They are worth exactly as much as the hard ones.
- PASS 2 — the ones you know how to start. Now you have the clock you saved.
- PASS 3 — whatever is left. Put a letter in every single box before time is called.

FOUR MOVES THAT BUY POINTS

- Backsolve. The answer is already on the screen. Drop each choice into the problem and see which one works — usually start with B or C, since they are often in the middle.
- Pick a number. If the answers are all letters, make $x = 2$ and run it through. One number kills three choices.
- Estimate first. Decide whether the answer should be positive, negative, bigger than 10, smaller than 1. Eliminate before you compute.
- Use the calculator for arithmetic, not for thinking. Reaching for it on 7×8 costs more time than it saves.

Tonight: sleep. Tomorrow: a pencil for your scratch paper, your calculator, and a full water bottle. You have done this math all year — this test just asks for it faster.